

a politician, Jeet gets into the shoes of a police officer who is at loggerheads with the leader. "The only dream we were chasing was to get the biggest ensemble to tell this story," says Pandey. Additionally, the show features Saswata Chatterjee a.k.a. Bob Biswas of *Kahaani*, Ritwik Bhowmik, Aadil Khan, Chitrangada Singh and Parambrata Chatterjee.

"This is something called destiny," says Prosenjit Chatterjee about sharing the screen with Jeet. "I knew Neeraj won't ask me to do something which is not meaningful." While a third Hindi web series (*Jubilee* and *Scoop*) for Chatterjee, for Jeet, it is not only his foray into long-format but also the first time he showcases his talents to a Hindi audience. "It's a no-brainer when it comes from Neeraj Pandey, a platform like Netflix and a show like *Khakee* which has won acclaim... this is the best launch," says Jeet.

It helped that *Khakee* came with a scale that neither had experienced in Bangla cinema. The show is in Hindi but the actors ensured they reached out to their respective fan bases by dubbing in Bengali. "There's a sprinkling of Bengali [in the Hindi version] as well," adds Pandey. "Wherever we felt we can speak in Bengali, we retained those lines."

Khakee: The Bengal Chapter enables Netflix India to make a major impact in the Bengal market

For Tanya Bami, Series Head, Netflix India, the show enables the platform to make a major impact in the Bengal market. In fact, Netflix hosted the trailer launch in Kolkata and courted the local media in early March. "Telling authentic stories with language not a barrier, being local, doing culturally rooted stories and going deeper with different backdrops" is top of the agenda for Netflix, says Bami. "We want Bengal to own the story and, hopefully, the voice will travel across India and beyond." ■

–Suhani Singh



Madhok is open to the idea of exploring popular Amazon Prime series in different formats, like a film on Mirzapur

be a good strategy to see if some of our popular IPs can be explored in different formats."

Madhok has seen first-hand how the OTT landscape has evolved. "The pace at which it has grown and the variety of storytelling it has enabled has exceeded expectations," he says. But, of late, there's talk of how OTT budgets are being slashed, stars taking precedence over talent and fear of censorship.

Every industry in "the beginning is growth-focused," says Madhok about the concerns. "Then it goes through a period where you figure out the right economics going forward. There was a plethora of OTT platforms and everybody was producing. Now... the amount of content produced has scaled down."

At Prime, he ensures that isn't the case. Among the 2025 titles Madhok is looking forward to are *Daring Partners* featuring Tamannah and Diana Penty, a new season of *The Family Man*, the Nagraj Manjule-directed *Matka King* starring Vijay Varma and Tamil original *Local Times*. "I hope we see continuity and disruption and newness," he says. He'd also like those calls to keep coming. ■

–Suhani Singh